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COVER STORY

Ancient Exploration to India and Africa: Eudoxus of Cyzicus

Cyzicus was a place of bustling harbors and active trade, ideally positioned between the Aegean and the Black Sea.

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Class=""> In the long annals of exploration, certain names gleam through the fog of legend: Pytheas of Massalia, who sailed beyond Britain into the icy seas of the north; Hanno the Carthaginian, who ventured down Africa's western coast; and Eudoxus of Cyzicus, the Hellenistic mariner whose final voyage, if ancient accounts are to be believed, may have taken him farther than any Greek before him, perhaps even around the entire continent of Africa.

Though history leaves his fate a mystery, Eudoxus stands as one of the most fascinating figures of the late Hellenistic world: an explorer, scientist, and dreamer caught between the age of Alexander's successors and the dawn of Roman dominion.

class="">Eudoxus was born in Cyzicus, a prosperous Greek city situated on the southern shore of the Propontis (modern Sea of Marmara). Cyzicus was a place of bustling harbors and active trade, ideally positioned between the Aegean and the Black Sea. It was renowned for its shipbuilding, commerce, and navigation, a fitting birthplace for a man destined to push the known boundaries of the ancient world.

class="">Little is known about Eudoxus's family or upbringing, but surviving fragments suggest that he was not merely a sailor but a polymath, educated in the Hellenistic tradition that prized knowledge of geography, astronomy, and mathematics. His contemporaries would have been familiar with the discoveries of Eratosthenes, who had measured the Earth's circumference, and Hipparchus, who refined celestial navigation. Such advances gave Eudoxus the intellectual tools to envision voyages that stretched far beyond the familiar horizons of the Mediterranean.

class="">Eudoxus's career first emerges from the mists of history during the reign of Ptolemy VIII Euergetes II (Physcon), the often-controversial ruler of Hellenistic Egypt. By the second century BCE, the Ptolemaic dynasty had turned Egypt into the commercial heart of the eastern

Mediterranean, with Alexandria as its gleaming capital and the Red Sea as its gateway to the riches of Arabia and India.

class="">Ptolemaic Egypt was deeply invested in maritime exploration, for beyond the narrow mouth of the Red Sea lay the lucrative trade routes of the Indian Ocean, routes that promised spices, ivory, silk, and precious stones. Egyptian and Greek merchants already navigated as far as the Horn of Africa and the Arabian Peninsula, but voyages to India itself were still extraordinary undertakings.

class="">According to Strabo, the Greek geographer writing in the early first century BCE, Eudoxus was commissioned by Ptolemy to undertake such a voyage. Departing from Berenice Troglodytica, a major Red Sea port, Eudoxus successfully navigated across the Arabian Sea, reaching the coasts of India, an achievement comparable to the later journeys of the Roman merchant fleets centuries afterward. He returned with rare goods and knowledge of new lands, and his success was reportedly followed by a second, longer voyage, further deepening the Ptolemies' commercial connections with the East.

class="">In the wake of these voyages, Eudoxus's reputation as one of the most accomplished navigators of his generation was secured. Yet the restless mariner seemed unsatisfied with mere repetition of known routes. The next stage of his life would take him from the orderly bureaucracies of Alexandria to the edge of the known world.

After his Indian ventures, Eudoxus travelled westward across the Mediterranean to Gades (modern Cádiz in Spain), one of the westernmost outposts of Hellenistic trade. Here, according to the later accounts of Posidonius (as preserved in Strabo and Pliny the Elder), he conceived an audacious idea: to attempt a circumnavigation of Africa, sailing from Gades southward along the Atlantic coast and then eastward, hoping eventually to reach the Red Sea and Egypt, thereby proving that Africa was surrounded by ocean.

This concept was not entirely new. Centuries earlier, Pharaoh Necho II of Egypt (c. 600 BCE) had allegedly commissioned Phoenician sailors to circumnavigate the continent, a feat reported by Herodotus. If true, Eudoxus would have been attempting to replicate and personally verify that legendary voyage. His first expedition, launched around 120 BCE, was ill-fated. After sailing south along the coast of Mauretania (roughly modern Morocco), his ships were driven ashore, possibly by contrary winds or currents. The expedition was forced to abandon the attempt, and Eudoxus returned to Gades with what knowledge he could salvage. Yet he was undeterred. Gathering funds and new vessels, he prepared a second attempt, outfitting three ships for what would become his final and most mysterious voyage.

The sources fall silent after that. Strabo tells us that Eudoxus set out again, determined to succeed where others had failed, and that he was never heard from afterward. Whether his fleet perished in storms, succumbed to disease, or was wrecked on the western coast of Africa, no one can say. Some romantic retellings speculate that he reached as far south as the Gulf of Guinea or even the Cape of Good Hope before being lost. Others suggest he may have made landfall and settled among coastal peoples, his story vanishing into local oral tradition.

Whatever the truth, Eudoxus's disappearance gave birth to one of antiquity's great maritime mysteries, a tale that would haunt geographers and explorers for centuries. His ambition to round Africa by sea prefigured by nearly 1,700 years the achievement of Bartolomeu Dias, who reached the Cape of Good Hope in 1488 CE, and Vasco da Gama, who sailed from Lisbon to India a decade later.

Most of what we know of Eudoxus comes from Strabo's *Geographica* (Book II, 3.4; Book XVII, 1.11) and fragments preserved by Pliny the Elder (*Natural History*, VI.36). Strabo's account, derived partly from Posidonius, mixes plausible navigational detail with the characteristic skepticism of a historian wary of sailors' tales. He records that Eudoxus "set out from Gades to reach India by sea," and though he acknowledges the report of his disappearance, he adds that "whether the story be true or not, it is at least consistent with reason."

Modern historians generally treat Eudoxus's Indian voyages as credible, consistent with Ptolemaic maritime expansion in the Red Sea but his African circumnav-

igation as speculative. The absence of corroborating documents, inscriptions, or material finds makes it impossible to confirm that he reached far beyond the coast of Mauretania. Some scholars have attempted to trace archaeological or ethnographic echoes of Hellenistic contact along the western African littoral. Isolated finds of Greco-Roman amphorae, anchors, and coins have turned up along the coasts of Morocco and Senegal, but none can be definitively linked to Eudoxus or his expedition. Rather, they attest to the broader maritime exchange networks that already touched the Atlantic fringe of North Africa in antiquity.

Still, Eudoxus's story reveals that the idea of Africa as a navigable continent surrounded by sea rather than merging endlessly with Asia was alive and discussed among Greek scholars long before Ptolemy's cartographic synthesis in the second century CE.

Even if his final voyage ended in tragedy, his achievements mark a turning point in the history of exploration. He was among the first known individuals to attempt global navigation using the scientific and observational methods of his time applying geography, astronomy, and logic to practical seamanship. His career embodied the spirit of the Hellenistic age: a fusion of empirical curiosity, daring, and restless expansion of the known world.

In a larger sense, Eudoxus symbolizes the bridge between the ancient and modern mentality of exploration. He was not merely a mythic adventurer; he was a product of a world where geography had become a science, and where human intellect sought to measure, map, and master the planet's extremities. His lost voyage reminds us that progress often depends on those willing to vanish beyond the horizon, taking with them both their hopes and their secrets.

In the quiet pages of ancient geography, Eudoxus's name remains a tantalizing footnote, neither wholly myth nor wholly history. The same uncertainty that clouds his end ensures his immortality. Like Pytheas in the north and Hanno in the south, he represents a lineage of explorers who dared to test the limits of the known world long before the Age of Discovery.

If one day an ancient wreck were discovered along the Atlantic coast of Africa, its timbers Greek, its cargo unmistakably Hellenistic perhaps the shadowy figure of Eudoxus of Cyzicus would step at last from legend into history. Until then, his story stands as a testament to the boundless curiosity of the human spirit, and to the enduring allure of the world's uncharted edges.

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This type of name was common in Greek culture, where personal names often reflected virtues or desirable

qualities. The feminine form of the name is Eudoxia (Εὐδοξία), which carries the same meaning.

It's worth noting that another famous bearer of the name was Eudoxus of Cnidus (Εὐδόξος ὁ Κνίδιος), a 4th-century BCE mathematician and astronomer, entirely distinct from Eudoxus of Cyzicus, the mariner and explorer of the 2nd century BCE.

Needless to say, Greek names are often descriptive, therefore, that linguistic habit makes it entirely plausible that Eudoxus literally eu-("good, well") and doxa ("repute, glory"), could have been an honorific or nickname granted after famous deeds rather than a birth-name.

In a culture that routinely turned virtues and accomplishments into personal labels, a mariner who brought home exotic cargoes, demonstrated exceptional seamanship, or even simply returned with striking tales of distant coasts would have been a natural candidate to acquire a name meaning "of good repute."

The name itself reads like an external judgment, less a neutral label one is born under and more the kind of commemorative phrase friends, patrons, or chroniclers might affix in praise.

The same cultural habit can be seen at work across Greek society as a whole, rulers and public figures commonly received epithets that recorded achievements or qualities, think of royal sobriquets like Sōtēros ("Saviour"), Euergetēs ("Benefactor"), or civic nicknames and honorifics carved into inscriptions.

At the personal level, storytellers and historians often refer to men by a descriptive tag (for example, "the Just," "the Bold," "the Long-lived") that highlights a salient reputation. For an adventurous navigator whose career included voyages to India and a legendary attempt to round Africa, a retroactive honorific such as Eudoxus fits neatly into that pattern: it communicates public appraisal rather than natal identity.

Linguistically, the structure of Εὐδόξος favors an interpretive reading. The eu- prefix is frequently productive in Greek for praise-derived formations (compare Euphemia, Euphrates in name-formation logic), and -doxos carries the evaluative sense of reputation or opinion. Names of this morphology are just as easily read as earned titles as they are read as hereditary names.

Given the antiquity of record-keeping and the tendency of later compilers (geographers, historians, encyclopedists) to summarize a life with a short, pithy label, it is not hard to imagine that the mariner's contemporaries or early biographers began calling him "Eudoxus" after his notable exploits and that the name then stuck in the literary tradition.

That said, the argument is necessarily conjectural, surviving sources do not record whether Eudoxus the

mariner was given that name at birth or acquired it later, and either possibility remains plausible. Nevertheless, when you place the matter in its Greek linguistic and social context a world comfortable with descriptive epithets, eager to honor public success with names, and supplied by writers who loved an apt label the hypothesis that Eudoxus was a post-facto epithet celebrating reputation and achievement is persuasive.

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FEATURES

The Antiquarian Roots of Modern Social Welfare

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

One of the most groundbreaking events of the late nineteenth century was the establishment of the world's first modern system of social security in Imperial Germany, with the state taking responsibility for safeguarding workers from everyday risks such as incapacity and old age.

Although the emergence of modern social welfare was product of both altruism and political expediency , with the creation of public entitlements such as retirement pensions, invalidity benefits , and accident and sickness insurance seen partly as a way of drawing support away from the political Left, it nevertheless began a positive trend that continues to the present day. While highly industrialised nation-states for several decades now, including Andorra , Liechtenstein and Monaco , have built up and maintained comprehensive income maintenance systems, many developing nations such as Nepal , Bangladesh , Pakistan and the Maldives in Asia, Burundi , Côte d'Ivoire and Sierra Leone in sub-Saharan Africa, and Panama and Suriname in the Americas have relatively recently embarked upon measures to broaden the coverage of and/or introduce new social security benefits. But welfare services in some form or another have existed long before the German reforms of the Nineteenth Century, with both individuals and state organisations offering support to those less able to help themselves. This common act of compassion is one of the more positive aspects of humanity and is a long-established part of the human tradition; one that has existed since the days of antiquity.

A notable example of ancient welfare can be found in the Byzantine Empire. For much of its existence, a vast multitude of social services were provided by the state, church and private citizens, amongst which included homes for the elderly , widows , and those unable to participate in the labour force, institutions for travellers and abandoned children, hostels for sick indigent individuals , orphanages, and (in the imperial capital) the granting of free bread . The emphasis placed on welfare was strongly influenced by the Christian teaching of agape (love) together with the philanthropic traditions of Greek society, with examples of social assistance in ancient Athens such as daily allowances for the handicapped and pensions for war orphans. Although the Byzantine Empire no longer exists, one can argue that its welfarist traditions live on today in the charitable works of Vatican City and Christian churches throughout the world.

Similar initiatives influenced by religious teaching were also carried out by early Islamic leaders , including the creation of social aid for the poor (such as payments to minors and those without work) regardless of their religion, together with the care of abandoned children and assistance during times of famine. A levy was also established known as the Zakat that has helped underprivileged people in many nations like Afghanistan since its inception. Religious doctrine shaped welfare provisions in Cambodia

during the reign of King Javarman VII who (influenced by Buddhism) presided over the inauguration of a nationwide system of public health facilities while ensuring that those living in poverty were provided with sustenance. In the Ottoman Empire (which included several modern states such as North Macedonia , Palestine , Montenegro , Albania , and a section of Croatia), prosperous members of different religious groups used their wealth for benevolent purposes such as the building of eating establishments for the impoverished. Morocco under the Merenid dynasty was no exception, with those in need attended to by organised charity. In Judaism, assisting the underprivileged has long been viewed as a religious duty, as characterised by a welfare tradition known as Tzedakah . This not only involves providing direct cash assistance to a deprived individual, but also helping to lift them out of poverty. One scholar from the 12th century drew up a comprehensive code of what forms this aid should take, amongst which includes taking on a person experiencing hardship as a partner or helping them find an occupation .

In Mesopotamia , temples provided succour to the poor, while under the guidance of Khosrow I the Sasanian Empire developed numerous schemes aimed at helping senior and impoverished citizens. In Ancient China, there were many instances of state-sponsored aid being provided such as the granting of food and allowances. In India, the establishment of free health care became a hallmark of the Gupta era, while many welfare programmes were put into operation under the Mauryan state . In pre-colonial Vietnam , direct relief such as medications and tents was granted by government representatives, while in Ancient Mongolia direct food assistance in crisis situations became a duty of the state. In Bhutan, a system has long operated known as Kidu in which the monarch comes to people's aid to ensure that their needs are met . In pre-industrial Japan, there were many examples of people in authority undertaking philanthropic works such as help for blind persons, lodgings for beggars and for artisans lacking employment, and repairs in dwellings inhabited by people living with leprosy.

In the Americas, the Aztecs and Incas embarked upon their own welfarist initiatives aimed at uplifting the poor, while in Africa the Mutapa became known for providing public relief to physically handicapped persons. In pre-colonial Zimbabwe , an intriguing system was set up in which chiefs put aside plots of land for community cultivation, with produce kept in granaries for emergencies. Prior to the arrival of colonialism, an altruistic practice was introduced in Rwanda known as Umuganda in which help was given to less fortunate members of the community (such as the elderly and disabled) including travel to health providers and the construction of dwellings. During the age of the Mali Empire (which included contemporary countries like Gambia, Senegal and Chad), a progressive charter laying out numerous rights and rules was drawn up, one of which was an obligation to assist the impoverished . Additionally, in the Kongo Kingdom (which is believed to have included portions of what became Gabon and the De-

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World War 2's Burma Campaign & Gurkha Lachhiman Gurung VC

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Lachhiman Gurung's story cannot be fully understood without appreciating the wider context of the Burma Campaign, one of the most demanding and least forgiving theatres of the Second World War. Fought across dense jungle, steep mountains, monsoon-soaked valleys, and primitive supply routes, the campaign pitted Allied forces against a Japanese army that had already demonstrated its ability to defeat larger, better-equipped opponents through mobility, surprise, and ferocious determination. Within this brutal environment, Gurung's stand in May 1945 represents not just individual heroism, but the culmination of years of attritional warfare in which endurance was often as decisive as firepower.

Born in 1917 in the village of Chhimba in Nepal's Gorkha district, Lachhiman Gurung grew up in a society where military service was both an economic opportunity and a source of deep cultural pride. Gurkha soldiers had been recruited into the British Indian Army since the early nineteenth century, valued for their toughness, adaptability, and fierce regimental loyalty. Gurung enlisted in the 8th Gurkha Rifles, a regiment that had already seen extensive action in both world wars. By the time Japan entered the conflict in Southeast Asia in 1941, Gurkha units were among the most experienced light infantry forces available to the British Empire, well-suited to jungle warfare and long-range patrolling.

The Japanese invasion of Burma in 1942 had driven British and Indian forces into a humiliating retreat to India, but by 1944 the strategic balance had begun to shift. The failure of the Japanese offensives at Imphal and Kohima marked a turning point, after which Allied forces, reorganized and resupplied, began a relentless advance back into Burma. By 1945, the Japanese 15th Army and associated formations were exhausted, understrength, and increasingly isolated, yet they remained dangerous opponents. Japanese doctrine emphasized aggressive night attacks, infiltration, and the willingness of small units to fight to the death rather than withdraw. Defensive positions were often assaulted repeatedly at close quarters, with grenades, bayonets, and hand-to-hand combat playing a decisive role.

It was against this backdrop that Rifleman Lachhiman Gurung found himself holding a forward position near Taungdaw on the night of 12–13 May 1945. His battalion was engaged in clearing remaining pockets of Japanese resistance as Allied forces pushed southwards. Forward positions such as Gurung's were particularly vulnerable, often lightly manned and deliberately exposed to give early warning of enemy movement. Japanese troops, skilled at moving silently through jungle and darkness, frequently attempted to overwhelm such posts with sudden grenade attacks followed by a close assault.

During the night, a determined Japanese attack fell upon Gurung's trench, which he shared with two

fellow Gurkhas. Grenades were hurled into the position in rapid succession. When one grenade landed directly among them, Gurung attempted to throw it clear, a reflexive act that likely saved the wider position even as it cost him dearly. The explosion tore off two of his fingers, shattered his right arm, and inflicted multiple wounds to his face and body. His two comrades were killed instantly. In most circumstances, such injuries would have rendered a soldier helpless, if not unconscious, but Gurung remained upright and aware, driven by a sense of duty that overrode shock and pain.

Alone in the trench and severely wounded, Gurung faced repeated Japanese assaults at extremely close range. The attacking soldiers were likely drawn from veteran infantry units accustomed to night fighting, armed with grenades, rifles, and bayonets, and prepared to press home attacks regardless of casualties. Gurung, unable to properly use his damaged arm, adapted with grim ingenuity. Using his remaining hand and his teeth, he picked up grenades and hurled them back at the attackers, while firing his weapon whenever possible. For several hours, he held his position, repelling one attack after another, despite loss of blood, exhaustion, and the knowledge that no immediate help could reach him.

By dawn, the Japanese attacks had ceased. The ground in front of Gurung's trench was strewn with enemy dead, grim evidence of the effectiveness of his solitary defense. More importantly, the position had not fallen. In the tightly interlinked defensive system of jungle warfare, the loss of a forward post could allow enemy forces to infiltrate behind the main line, threatening encirclement or collapse. Gurung's refusal to yield under such conditions almost certainly prevented further casualties among his unit and contributed directly to the success of the local operation.

The award of the Victoria Cross recognized not only the extraordinary courage displayed but also the broader military significance of Gurung's actions. His citation highlighted his "indomitable spirit" and "complete disregard for his own safety," qualities that epitomized the ideal of the Gurkha soldier. At a time when the Burma Campaign was approaching its conclusion, his story resonated strongly with Allied forces who had endured years of hardship in one of the war's harshest environments.

After surviving his wounds, Lachhiman Gurung was discharged from the army with a disability pension. He returned to Nepal, where, like many Gurkha veterans, he lived a modest life far removed from the battlefields that had defined his youth. Despite being one of the few Nepalese recipients of the Victoria Cross, he remained characteristically humble, rarely speaking about his wartime experiences unless pressed. In later years, he was honored at commemorative events and remembered with deep respect within Gurkha circles and beyond. Lachhiman Gurung died in 2004, leaving behind a legacy that stands as one of the most remarkable individual acts of bravery in the Second World War and a powerful reminder of the human endurance displayed during the long and punishing struggle.

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The 1858 Lincoln-Douglas Debates

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Now, as in then there can be but one supreme issue, that between right and wrong. In our country there are no ruling classes. The right to direct public affairs, according to his might and influence and conscious belongs to the humblest as well as the greatest... But it is times of danger, crucial moments, which bring into action the high moral quality of the citizenship of America. The people are always true. They are always right, and I have the abiding faith that they will remain so Robert Todd, Lincoln, speaking at the Galesburg, celebration 1896. (A, 314)

The weather was so extremely dusty due to the preceding drought that the streets resemble the vast smoke houses because of the dust picked up by the thousands of spectators, economic recession, deflated land values brought railroad construction to a halt as Illinois Central and Michigan Central Railroad; and reduced the money supply of the banknotes from \$215 million to \$115 million. Money grew suddenly so scarce with us that a man possessing \$10 in coins or in notes of a solvent bank might call himself a capitalist, Carl Scharz, a German, immigrant (a,XI) When considering the series of 1858 debates between Abraham Lincoln of the Republican Party and Stephen Douglas of the Democratic Party I think of civility and decorum. In reality the discussions were quite the opposite. They both used a lot of sarcasm did a lot of name calling to the degree that it most likely would be unable to be aired on network television. Until 1913, senators were elected not by popular vote, but by the General Assembly made up of their Representatives. Lincoln and Douglas were trying to win the votes of the State Legislator of the two chambers of the Illinois General Assembly. This was the first time debates were held between Senate candidates (B).

Originally, Lincoln proposed a series of 50 debates. Douglas agreed to 7 “joint discussions” because there were nine congressional districts in Illinois (B). He was frustrated that in the two districts he already spoke in, Lincoln would arrive two days after he left and defend his views. This left Douglas unable to rebuke. With crowds ranging from 1,000 to 20,000 spectators, it was a huge media story. Two rival newspapers in the Chicago area hired shorthand stenographers to capture every word of the candidate’s debates. From the articles published, Lincoln prepared scrapbooks that he had published by an Ohio printer to assist in his later bid for the Presidency of the United States.

While their primary focus was on slavery, they also debated popular sovereignty, the implication of the Dred Scott decision, the morality of enslavement, and the potential of a fractured union. Douglas chose to speak first in four of the seven debates. He was allowed sixty minutes to present his point with the challenger being (Lincoln) given a ninety-minute response followed by thirty-minute rejoinder by the first candidate. Douglas argued his belief that residents should decide if the state is free or not (Popular

Sovereignty), and that the Supreme Court ruled in the Dred Scott case the slaves aren’t people and could be brought into a free state and remain slaves. He was worried about the possibility of a fractured union. However, he believed that Popular Sovereignty would solve that.

Lincoln argued against slavery on moral grounds. He avoided stating that the races are equal, he just argued that slavery shouldn’t be expanded into new territories. If the territory already had slaves, they would be able to keep them. He felt that the Dred Scott decision had critical implications on the expansion of slavery, and he too was concerned about the division of the union, but felt only keeping slavery where it existed while not expanding into new territories would solve it. He spoke of the “eternal struggle’ between right and wrong when speaking of slavery, he mentioned “two principles that stood face to face since the beginning of time. The one of the common rights of humanity and the other the divine right of kings.” Lincoln used the house divided metaphor as early as 1843. He shared the biblical phrase “a house divided cannot stand” as a warning to unify the members of his political party. The names of parties are the same, but their principals and positions have flipped in the last one hundred fifty years.

As the debates drew to a close, an observer noted that Douglas had lost his voice when Lincoln’s voice and spirit were intact. Lincoln won the popular vote, but lost the vote in in the General Assembly, Lincoln was confident even though he had lost because he had won the popular vote. Lincoln had gained notoriety and used the debates to help propel him into the White House. Lincoln and Douglas had disagreed for many years. However, Douglas supported Lincoln during the war.

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George Levrier-Jones

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Howard Carter and the Discovery of King Tutankhamun's Tomb

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

When asked about the Ancient Egyptians, and in particular King Tutankhamun, many will think of iconography like mummies wrapped in bandages, imposing pyramids and talk of curses. In November 1922, British archaeologist Howard Carter discovered the sealed tomb of King Tutankhamun and it became an international sensation. When his benefactor Lord Carnarvon died suddenly in April 1923, the press had no trouble in whipping up a sensationalist story of ill fortune and supernatural curses. Carter and his team were thrown into the limelight of hungry gazes tracking their every move, waiting for something to happen. Not only did Carter's excavation site become one of interest, but also publicized Egyptology as a branch of archaeology often previously overlooked. Frequently the focus has been on the discovery itself rather than the discoverer and how Carter dedicated his life to Egypt that peaked with his career defining excavation in 1922. This article will explore the excavation of King Tutankhamun with focus on the Egyptologist, Howard Carter and his relentless search for the tomb.

Howard Carter's story is one of a series of coincidences, hard work in the dust and rubble of excavation sites and unwavering conviction that there was more to discover. He was not content until he had seen every inch of the Valley of the Kings and only then would he resign to the fact there was nothing left to discover. Carter's fascination with Egypt began when he was a child and his family moved from London to Norfolk due to his childhood illness. (1) A family friend, Lady Amherst owned a collection of Ancient Egyptian antiquities, which piqued Carter's interest. In 1891, at seventeen years old, his artistic talent impressed Lady Amherst and she suggested to the Egypt Exploration Fund that Carter assist an Amherst family friend in an excavation site in Egypt despite having no formal training. He was sent as an artist to copy the decorations of the tomb at the Beni Hasan cemetery of the Middle Kingdom. (1)

During this time he was influential in improving the efficiency of copying the inscriptions and images that covered the tombs. By 1899, he was appointed Inspector of Monuments in upper Egypt at the personal recommendation of the Head of the Antiquities Services, Gaston Maspero. Throughout his work with the Antiquities Services he was praised and seen in high regard for the way he modernized excavation in the area with his use of a systematic grid system and his dedication to the preservation and accessibility to already existing sites. Notably, he oversaw excavations in Thebes and supervised exploration in the Valley of the Kings by the remorseless tomb hunter and American businessman, Theodore Davis who dominated the excavation sites in the valley. In 1902, Carter started his own search in the valley with some success but nothing that was quite like King Tutankhamun's tomb. His career took a turn in 1903 when a volatile dispute broke out between Egyptian guards and French tourists, referred as the Saqqara Affair, where tourists broke into a cordoned off

archaeological site. Carter sided with the Egyptian guards, warranting a complaint from French officials and when Carter refused to apologize he resigned from his position. This incident emphasizes Carter's dedication, even when faced with confrontation, to the rules set out by the Antiquities Service and the preservation of excavation sites.

For three years he was unemployed and moved back to Luxor where he sold watercolor paintings to tourists. In 1907, Carter was introduced to George Herbert, the fifth earl of Carnarvon (Lord Carnarvon) and they worked together in Egypt excavating a number of minor tombs located in the necropolis of Thebes. They even published a well-received scholarly work, *Five Years' Exploration at Thebes* in 1911. (2) Despite the ups and downs of Carter's career, he was still adamant that there was more to find in the Valley of the Kings, notably the tomb of the boy king. During his employment under Carnarvon, Carter was also a dealer in Egyptian antiquities and made money from commission selling of Carnarvon's finds to the Metropolitan Museum of New York. (2) After over a decade of searching and working in the area, Carter finally had a breakthrough in 1922.

The Valley of the Kings, located near Luxor, was a major excavation site and by the early 1900s, it was thought that there was nothing left to discover and everything to be found was already in the hands of private collectors, museums and archaeologists. Davis was certain of this fact so much so that he relinquished his excavation permit. He'd been excavating in the area between 1902 to 1914 on the West bank of Luxor until the outbreak of The Great War in 1914. By the end of the war, the political and economic landscape of Europe and the Egypt had changed significantly. In 1919, Egypt underwent a massive political shift with the Egyptian Revolution that saw the replacement of the Pro-British government that had ruled since 1882 with a radical Egyptian government that focused on a strong sense of Nationalism. This political shift also changed the way that British and foreign archaeologists could operate in the area. In particular, the government limited the exportation of artefacts found and asserted the claim on all "things to be discovered." (3) This meant that everything found in Egyptian territory was the property of Egypt and not of the individual or party that discovered it. Previously, it was a lot easier for artefacts to be exported into the hands of private collectors and sold or worked on the partage system of equally sharing the finds between the party working on the site. All excavations had to be supervised by the Antiquities Services. These regulations only expanded what was already outlined in the 1912 Law of Antiquities No. 14 regarding ownership, expert and permits. (4) Any exceptions or special concessions had to be approved by the Antiquities Services and have the correct permit issued. In many ways, this 'crack down' on free use of Egyptian territory pushed back against the British colonial rule and the desire to take back what was rightfully Egyptian and taking pride in Egyptian culture and heritage.

The strict approach towards foreign excavators

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Gear Post 2026

Tynan · Tynan (personal)

First, for future people who are going to ask me next year when the gear post is coming: it will come as soon as I can get it done. I'll do a gear post every year until I die or stop traveling, so no need to worry about it. The delay this year was coordinating a time to get the pictures taken, but hopefully the new stuff makes it worth it. I think this is one of the best gear posts ever!

In case you haven't read the last 18 years of gear posts, my goal is to have the best possible gear with the most wide ranging capability in the smallest form factor possible. Yes, I know some of this stuff is expensive and borderline ridiculous, but I travel for at least half the year and the incremental benefits are worth it to me.

They may not be worth it for you, but at least you'll know what the best possible thing is and can work backwards from there. At the very least, get all wool clothing and shoot for around a 20 liter backpack. I have friends with totally different priorities and gear, but they all stick with around the same backpack size.

Some links are affiliate links. Some aren't. I promise it has zero bearing on whether or not I recommend things. I also sometimes receive products, and that does make me more likely to try a product, but it won't affect how I rank them.

As with last year, I will note when things are new and perfect. Perfect doesn't mean it's permanent, but it means that there are no obvious improvements that I would hope for with current technology.

The only thing that was removed this year and not replaced with something else was the travel blazer. I still have it, but it's not in my bag most of the time.

Wool and Prince Merino Henley Perfect

This is my fourth year using the Henley instead of a more traditional button-down. I like both, but the Henley is so soft and comfortable that it makes a big difference when trying to sleep on planes or curl up and read a book. It also has a lot more stretch, so it's better for active things. It also seems to be totally indestructible. I've never replaced it and it looks exactly as it did new. (Wow, I just saw the new colors they have when I clicked to make sure the link worked... maybe I will be an ochre guy if this one ever wears out)

Buy at Wool and Prince

Wool and Prince V-Neck T-Shirt

This might be the longest running item on the gear list, though I'm not sure. Maybe I should start tracking how many years everything makes it and it would be like a competition. As always, I love this shirt but wish it had a pocket for folded up boarding passes.

If you're new to the gear post, this is probably a good time to say that the only reason I'm able to keep my packing so light is because I wear wool. I routinely wear this shirt 7-14 days in a row without washing it, and it stays fresh. Wool and Prince is my favorite wool company, but there are other good ones out there, too. I damaged my Wool and Prince one this year so it was a good opportunity to try SmartWool again, but I bought another Wool and Prince shortly after.

This is literally the only shirt I wear all year, even when I'm at home, unless I have to go to a wedding. I generally switch colors every year, which shocks the people in my life because they're so used to seeing me in one color.

When I became the godfather to my friend Noah's daughter, he got a Wool and Prince V-Neck embroidered with "El Padrino" for me.

The v-neck is now less deep than previous years. I wish it was the old depth, but overall it's about the same.

Buy at Wool and Prince

Wool and Prince Stretch Canvas Pants

These pants made it another year! They look like black jeans, have a really good amount of stretch, and are comfortable and durable, but I've had issues with the pockets ripping in the past, as have my friends.

But... they have redesigned the pockets and use new material. So far so good. I actually haven't been wearing these recently because I'm testing the new denim jeans, but I'm not ready to switch my recommendation just yet.

These are 55% merino wool, which is higher than most wool pant blends. You need some material besides wool to keep it durable, but despite these being a higher amount they have been extremely durable. I've put them through their paces, worn them every non-warm day, and they're in perfect shape.

These pants were gone last year, but apparently they were just out of stock. Phew!

Buy at Wool and Prince

Faherty All Day Shorts 9" New

A year or two ago a reader suggested Faherty shorts, and I was lucky enough to remember the name as I was looking for a new pair. And... WOW are these shorts great!

What makes shorts like these special is that they look good enough to wear every day as shorts, but they dry quickly and have a draw string. The draw string doesn't serve a huge function if the shorts are the right size, but by tying it together and popping it over the waistband I feel like the shorts look like a bathing suit enough that you don't look out of place swimming in them. All of the pockets have a mesh portion to drain.

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The Many Faces of Anne Boleyn – King Henry VIII's Second Wife

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Divorced, beheaded, died. Divorced, behead, survived. Six women reduced to a simple sentence. Yet those few words oversimplify Anne Boleyn. Anne a woman who spent her entire life defying labels and social expectations that were forced upon her, first as a woman and later as Queen of England.

Anne's story has often been simplified as a one of love, loss, and betrayal. However, this version fails to mention the woman who dared to defy the patriarchy — a woman whose ambition and passion once turned the head of King Henry VIII — a relationship that would end with her being tried, imprisoned, and later executed by the axe. Does labelling Anne as a traitor, temptress or tragic Queen limit our understanding of who she was?

Anne Boleyn was unlike any woman that the English court and Henry VIII had ever seen — her wit, charm and intelligence made her irresistible and dangerous. Far from the delicate obedient ladies in court, Anne was the least likely contender to be Queen due to her family's unconventional rise to power.

When she first stepped into the court at 21 Anne was hard to ignore, not one to rely on Tudor softness and submission, her musicality, intelligence, and fashion set her worlds apart from the traditional English court.

Anne's unconventional behaviour came from a decade spent in France, during her early years she served as a lady in waiting to Mary Tudor who was briefly married to King Louis XII of France. After that she remained in France serving as a maid of honour to Queen Claude. Her exposure to French culture, language and belief systems would later influence both her rise and inevitable downfall in her later life.

Upon her return to the English court Anne was transformed into a sophisticated and cultured woman who would attract the attention of Henry Percy (Earl of Northumberland), Sir Thomas Wyatt, and later King Henry VIII.

Her power lay not just in her intelligence, but in her refusal to be Henry's mistress — a decision that gave her unprecedented influence over the King and the court. Unlike her sister Mary who was Henry's mistress, Anne set her standards higher and in doing so she became the unattainable prize — a challenge that fuelled Henry's obsession.

Anne's reputation as a temptress has continued long after her death, her ambition, confidence and passion were reduced to a sexist stigma. As her influence over the King and the Court grew, so did the danger she posed to the men in power such as Thomas Cromwell. The very qualities that once made her irresistible to the men around her, now marked her as a threat, a vixen that was destined to fall from grace. The other Boleyn girl who captivated the King with

her wisdom and beauty would be soon cast into the shadows as a traitor to the King.

The very foundation of Anne Boleyn's rise and inevitable fall from grace entwines with Henry VIII's desperation for a male heir. Prior to their marriage Anne Boleyn promised him the son he desperately wanted that his previous marriage could not give him. Yet despite her dedication and will power she failed to secure the future of the Tudor dynasty which in turn would solidify her position as Queen of England. The pressure to produce a male heir mixed with Henry's shifting desires made Anne a target. Anne's status was attacked both personally and politically as Henry's quest for a son continued, and her failure to fulfil would mark the beginning of her end.

Despite several failed pregnancies and the birth of her daughter Elizabeth, the King's frustration grew. Influential courtiers such as Thomas Cromwell and Anne's own Uncle Thomas Boleyn fuelled the fire. Cromwell saw Anne's failure as an opportunity to orchestrate charges of adultery, incest, and treason against her. Beyond her issues with delivering an heir, it was Anne's intelligence and assertiveness in court that fuelled her enemy's hatred towards her. Her downfall is a warning to any woman daring to have power in a patriarchal society.

With Anne's failures and the charges in place a public trial was inevitable- and Thomas Cromwell ensured the system worked to transform the Queen's religious ambition into a criminal act in eyes of a patriarchal court. Anne Boleyn was a woman who spoke with influence, she was also a vocal supporter of Protestant reform, aligning herself with a faith that was radicalised unsettled the catholic court. Her promotion of protestant beliefs and reformist teachings stemmed from her early years in France where she was exposed to them. These views in turn with her refusal to be a passive queen made her many enemies within the traditional court that was based on patriarchal beliefs. To men like Cromwell, Anne's qualities made her dangerous, by painting her as morally and politically corrupt. Cromwell weaponised Anne's gendered defiance and her reformed ideology all under the guise of loyalty to the King.

In the afternoon of May 2nd, 1536, Anne Boleyn was taken from Greenwich Palace to the Tower of London on the charges of adultery, incest, and treason. These charges against her were extreme by design she was accused of committing adultery twenty times with five different men including incest with her own brother George Boleyn. Furthermore, she was accused of plotting to kill her husband the King. The charges were deliberately designed to destroy her morally, politically, and personally. Adultery by a Queen in Tudor England questioned the legitimacy of the heir to the throne as it endangered the royal line. Meanwhile incest added to the horror that ensured public outrage towards Anne. The case was backed by questionable evidence; confessions extracted under torture, inconsistent dates that would frequently change or be retracted by men who would later die in disgrace. But the whole truth was

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Day Care

Aea Varfis-van Warmelo · Granta

She eventually wrote this about herself: I do not deserve nature. I want to have sex in the daylight. She would not include in her dating profile where she was raised, on the West Coast with drought-appropriate faucets and toilets, and chickens. (Her mother had kept them around for company, and for food.) She understood the potential consequences of presenting her needs completely yet concisely online. The advice, overwhelming, that she had scrolled through recommended doing the exact opposite. Females advised other females to save themselves from immediate or eventual scrutiny by hiding their true self.

Before going to all the trouble of building an online profile, which was enormously time-consuming (she had a job and an infant to care for, alone, in Los Angeles), she first ran the idea of seeking daytime sex by other mothers online who called her a slut, which she didn't fight, though she recognized that perhaps she would be better off looking for guidance elsewhere. She then took the sex-nature conundrum – as she came to see the proposition – to her boss, a wealthy art collector, who was also kind. She explained to her boss, an actual widow herself (not a mother raising a child alone like she was), over fistfuls of fresh bread, that she had found this specific platform for weirdos on recommendation from the other mothers who had publicly slammed her for being a new mom with sick slut desires, but who had privately called her their hero for putting herself out there. Her boss wanted in, too.

As they waited for the housepainters to arrive, she and her boss took out a legal pad and began compiling their notable attributes. From there, they imputed the data onto the dating app open on their computers. Her boss said that she just wanted someone to prepare her a perfect omelet after fucking, and she would provide all the ingredients to make this happen. For her profile, she had inched open a bit more – there was her fear of nature, as she wrote, her mother (an abyss), her preference for waffles over pancakes, and of course her want of sex with either gender (both have feminine and masculine auras) between when work ended in the late afternoon, and before picking her daughter up from daycare. MartyArty immediately responded, 'How old?'

The doorbell rang. Her dinging phone was ricocheting on her lap. She looked to find a flurry of texts that had come in from her mother, who wrote saying that she was at the airport in Los Angeles to see her daughter. Heavy storms were on their way. Her mother loved a good storm. Everything was happening at once. The house-painters had arrived, as her boss's small dogs barked in defense of their property. She removed the breadcrumbs from the table with her hands, and thought about how she used to be a pretty good artist. Now, she made bad mom art to care for herself. The red chip bullshit stuff. (She had a dozen videos starring her daughter using plastic dinosaurs positioned inside of their refrigerator make-believing 'existence.') On her own time, she labored to convince herself that the mundane,

the inappropriately, excessively lackluster – soiled diapers, pumping while Googling trash pick-up schedules – was enough to feel awake. Then her aching breasts were right there to remind her of her need for nature. She had read articles on motherhood that suggested being horny, stimulating yourself, helps with the milk flow. Though the experts didn't express themselves in those exact words. What they recommended was to scroll through images of your infant as you pumped to get the liquids flowing.

She drove to the Los Angeles International Airport to pick up her mother, as she had no other choice. 'Don't move to Orem. Utah's really a desert. Remember the dead squirrel?' her mother said, fresh off her flight from Portland, Oregon, hopping into her daughter's Honda Fit. She touched her mother's knee: bare, solid, beautifully familiar. Her mother refused to wear anything other than summer clothes when visiting her daughter in California. The two of them – mother and daughter – tucked inside the Fit like sticks of gum in the humid California weather, then sped away.

A few weeks before, after several days of heavy rainfall, before her mother's visit to experience more heavy rainfall, before posting her dating profile, and before the sun had come out momentarily though not long enough to dry the land – she had found a dead, very plump, and very well-endowed squirrel. Its body was on the driveway belonging to the Modernist mansion for sale next door to her duplex. She was charmed by the totem. The squirrel, despite no longer living, had an unmistakable, masterful erection, striking like the Gothic spires adorning Paris. With a nearby palm frond that had fallen, she scooped up the squirrel and shuttled him to the top of the hill in Silver Lake, where she deposited him inside of a smooth grave that she had carved from the mud beneath an impromptu shrine assembled from a half-eaten bag of Doritos, and an empty can of Pure La Croix. His resting place. Not far from where she and her daughter slept. Right at the hem of the sky.

Fast-forward, and now her mother was in her car, visiting without having been invited. Her mother was the reason she hadn't left Los Angeles to join her husband in rural Utah, where he had taken a new position autonomously, without a family discussion. Her mother was the reason she had not left her well-paying job managing a wealthy woman's day-to-day affairs, as well as her art collection. Her mother was the reason she had not given up their cute one-bedroom 'treehouse' to join her husband, where he had taken a coveted position with an updated job title in an educational institution (Student Operations Specialist Coordinator), apparently a dinosaur role (that even the name change would not be able to reverse), that was increasingly near-impossible to come by. He had signed a one-year lease on a rental without consulting her. He was there, and now, eagerly, impatiently, waiting for her and their six-month-old daughter to join him in Utah to begin their future. Her mother had said to her daughter that to leave her role with the wealthy art collector, who provided quality kickbacks, who was notorious for her unexpected kindness – like passing her chilled bottles of real champagne from the country of

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The 166 Roman Envoy Mission to China

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

In 166 CE, an ambassador described in Chinese sources as having come from “Andun, King of Da Qin”, almost certainly referring to a Roman ruler, traditionally identified as Marcus Aurelius Antoninus, arrived at the court of Emperor Huan of the Eastern Han Dynasty. Although modern historians debate whether these envoys were official Roman diplomats or merchants presenting themselves as such, their appearance in Chinese court records represents one of the most intriguing episodes of long-distance contact between the Mediterranean world and imperial China. The mission is described primarily in the Hou Hanshu (Book of the Later Han), which notes that the newcomers travelled by way of Rinan (in modern Vietnam), bringing ivory, rhinoceros horn, and tortoise-shell, luxury items more typical of Southeast Asian trade networks than of Roman industry. This mixture of goods has led scholars to argue that the delegation may have originated from Roman trading communities in the Indian Ocean rather than from Rome itself, yet the Chinese understood it as Rome’s first formal attempt to open relations with the Han state.

The commercial motive behind the ambassador’s extraordinary journey was unmistakable. By the 2nd century CE, Rome had an enormous appetite for silk, a commodity so prized that Seneca and other Roman writers complained that the elite spent too freely on it. Roman merchants already operated in Indian Ocean ports such as Barygaza, Muziris, and Arikamedu, where intermediaries brought silk from Central Asia and China. Direct access to China promised greater profit and prestige. From the Chinese perspective, Roman glassware, metalwork, Mediterranean wines, and high-quality woolen textiles were especially valued. Although the Hou Hanshu does not record a specific trade treaty resulting from the encounter, it emphasizes that the presence of the envoys was understood to signal Rome’s wish to establish direct commercial relations, bypassing the Parthian Empire, whose control over the Silk Road had long restricted contact between the two great civilizations.

Chinese records further suggest that relations were warm, with the emperor receiving the envoys, accepting their tribute, and permitting them to trade. The Han state typically treated foreign embassies as part of a tribute-exchange system rather than as partners in bilateral treaties of the Roman type. Thus, while no formal treaty is mentioned, participation in the tribute system effectively functioned as a state-sanctioned trade agreement, allowing the envoys to exchange their offerings for Chinese goods at highly favorable rates. The mission therefore symbolized an official acknowledgment—at least from the Chinese perspective—of the desirability of regular exchange between the two imperial powers.

Documentary evidence for the expedition is strongest on the Chinese side. The Hou Hanshu entry is

concise but unambiguous, describing Da Qin (Rome) as a powerful, wealthy empire and emphasizing the significance of the envoys’ arrival. Roman sources, by contrast, are silent. This absence has various explanations: the original embassy may not have been dispatched by the imperial government at all; Roman historians may not have considered a distant eastern diplomatic venture noteworthy; or the mission may have been too commercially oriented to appear in official state records. Nevertheless, Roman coins have been found across India and Southeast Asia, including 2nd-century gold aurei of Marcus Aurelius, confirming extensive Roman presence and trade in the regions through which the so-called embassy would have travelled. At the opposite end of the route, excavations in China have uncovered small quantities of Mediterranean glass, Roman-style metal vessels, and even a few Roman coins, demonstrating that Roman luxury items did reach Han territory through long-distance exchange, even if not in large volume.

Archaeological evidence from Central Asia enriches this picture of indirect but persistent contact. Finds of Roman glassware and silver in sites along the Tarim Basin and in Gansu province echo the Hou Hanshu’s descriptions of Da Qin goods. Meanwhile, discoveries in Roman Egypt—including papyri from the Red Sea ports of Berenike and Myos Hormos—record thriving trade with India, where Chinese goods were already appearing by the 1st and 2nd centuries CE. This network of merchants, brokers, and maritime middlemen produced the logistical conditions that allowed the 166 CE envoys to reach the Han court, whether as imperial ambassadors or ambitious traders seeking official recognition.

The benefits of this encounter were largely symbolic, yet they had real economic implications. For China, the visit confirmed Da Qin as a prosperous and orderly counterpart at the other end of the world, one worthy of direct ties. For Rome—or at least the Roman merchants operating in the Indian Ocean—the embassy provided access to China’s tribute-exchange market, which offered silk, lacquerware, and fine ceramics unattainable elsewhere. The long-term impact was limited, partly because both empires soon faced internal crises—the Marcomannic Wars and plague in Rome, and the weakening of Han authority in China—but the 166 CE contact remains a remarkable moment in ancient global history. It represents the closest documented diplomatic interaction between the westernmost and easternmost great empires of antiquity, an episode that highlights the sophistication, ambition, and connectivity of the ancient world.

Roman coins in India, Mediterranean artefacts in China, and evidence of thriving Indo-Roman trade networks together paint a vivid picture of the interconnectedness that made such a journey possible.

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7 Principles of Inner Excellence to Stay Calm Under Fire | Jim Murphy

Vicky · Farnam Street (fs.blog)

Top Performance Coach Jim Murphy reveals how to eliminate fear, master pressure, and unlock elite performance.

The Three Elements of Inner Excellence

How to Navigate Failure and Learn From It

Does Success Equal Happiness?

Daily Mantras for Success

Jim spent 5 years writing *Inner Excellence*, the mental toughness manual that shot from obscurity to #1 New York Times bestseller overnight when star athlete A. J. Brown was caught reading it on the sidelines of a NFL playoff game.

Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | YouTube | Transcript | X

A personal coach to professional baseball players and Olympic athletes, he teaches how extraordinary performance and a meaningful life follow the exact same path.

Selflessness is fearless.

Presence beats confidence.

An easier life is not the best life.

Your mind quits long before your body.

Aging is the aggressive pursuit of comfort.

You're only as stable as what you worship.

The best performers don't get tentative after mistakes.

There's no failure, only feedback.

Your life is a reflection of your beliefs.

Busyness is how we avoid facing ourselves.

Money amplifies who you already are.

The best life has one foot in joy, one foot in suffering.

Don't build a life you need to escape from.

What you really want isn't success, it's to feel fully alive.

Discomfort is your teacher.

Your first step is too big. Make it smaller.

Everyone worships something. Choose wisely.

Are you running on clean fuel or dirty fuel? Dirty fuel burns hot but costs you inner peace.

Extraordinary performance and the best possible life are the same path.

The ego promises love through success. It's lying.

Without a clear purpose, you'll stay busy avoiding yourself.

Confidence makes you careless. Presence keeps you sharp.

Give 100% of what's available today, not 100% of perfect.

If you build a life you want to escape, you've built the wrong life. The more talent you have, the deeper the achievement trap.

Perfectionism limits excellence.

Self-centeredness is the root cause of fear.

You are not your mind.

The person with the most control of their inner world has the most power.

Every circumstance and every person you encounter is here to teach you and help you—it's all working for your good.

Your life is a reflection of your beliefs.

Self-centeredness is the root cause of fear.

We all have the same deep needs and the same desires.

Everyone does the best they can with what they have in their hearts.

The map is not the territory.

You are not your mind.

The problem is not the problem, the problem is the way you're thinking about it.

There is no failure, only feedback.

The person with the most control of their inner world has the most power.

The post 7 Principles of Inner Excellence to Stay Calm Under Fire | Jim Murphy appeared first on Farnam Street .

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The Forgotten Bombers That Led the Way: America's Vivid Assembly Ships of World War II

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

During the height of the air war over Europe, large groups of American heavy bombers climbed out of East Anglia almost every morning. For many people living in the region, the sound and sight of those aircraft became a familiar part of the conflict. The United States Army Air Forces depended heavily on the B-17 Flying Fortress and the B-24 Liberator for its daylight strategy, and their departures became routine. What rarely receives the same attention is the role of a handful of older bombers that helped bring order to these departures. These were the assembly ships, painted in bright and sometimes unusual colors so crews could spot them quickly against the English sky.

The Challenge of Bringing Order to the Skies

From 1943 onward, the Eighth Air Force expanded its operations across East Anglia. Airfields were spread across Norfolk, Suffolk, and Cambridgeshire, and each one sent aircraft into the same busy morning sky. Every bomber had to find its place in a larger group, climb steadily, and keep to the timetable. Weather often interfered, and crews still adjusting to British conditions sometimes struggled to identify other aircraft in the haze.

The result was predictable. Aircraft sometimes climbed into the same airspace. Near misses were reported frequently. Several bombing missions suffered delays because the formations failed to gather quickly enough. Although ground control could guide departures, it could not solve the issue of identifying other aircraft in the air. Another solution was needed, one that crews could see without relying on radio contact or clear skies.

A Practical Innovation in a Growing Air War

The answer was the assembly ship. These were older bombers nearing the end of their combat life. Some had battle damage that made long missions impossible, while others had simply become worn. Instead of being scrapped immediately, many were converted into highly visible airborne rally points. Each bomb group had one, sometimes two, depending on operational needs.

The idea was straightforward. The assembly ship took off first and climbed into a holding pattern above its home base. Newer aircraft took off next and circled until they spotted the brightly painted machine overhead. Once enough aircraft had gathered, the assembly ship guided the formation into the correct climbing pattern and direction of travel. After completing the task, it returned to base. It did not cross the North Sea or accompany the mission toward its target.

Color Schemes Designed to Be Impossible to Miss

The thing that makes assembly ships so memorable today is their appearance. Because they never flew into enemy territory, camouflage was unnecessary. Visibility

became the priority. Groups across the Eighth Air Force began to develop their own designs, often with considerable imagination.

One aircraft might be painted bright yellow with red chevrons. Another might have wide black spots across a silver fuselage. Some had candy-striped tails. Others carried oversized geometric shapes or checkerboard patterns. A few used contrasting panels of green and white. The design language varied, but every scheme aimed at the same goal. Crews had to recognize the ship instantly, even in bad weather.

These color schemes created some of the most distinctive aircraft of the Second World War. They were not meant to impress the enemy or hide from it. They were meant for the airmen who needed to find their group quickly at dawn.

A large formation needed clarity and coordination.

George Levrier-Jones

Conversions and Modifications

The aircraft chosen for this role were usually B-17s or B-24s. Each type required a fair amount of modification. Guns were removed, which reduced weight and made the aircraft easier to climb. Armor plate was often taken out for the same reason. Much of the interior was removed, along with equipment that was no longer needed. Lightening the aircraft made it easier for the assembly ship to get up early and remain overhead long enough for the rest of the group to form up.

Some groups gave their assembly ships names that embraced their unusual appearance. The 458th Bomb Group operated a B-24 known as "Spotted Cow". Another group had "The Green Dragon", painted in a vivid green finish with yellow markings. There were others, including "The Jolly Roger" and "Fightin' Sam". The names added a touch of character, but the paintwork did most of the talking.

Routine Work That Never Reached the Headlines

Assembly ships rarely appear in wartime newsreels or photographs. Their work was uneventful by design. They did not fly through flak or fighter attack. They were not part of the dramatic footage that accompanied raids on Berlin or the Ruhr. Yet their flights were essential. A large formation needed clarity and coordination. Without it, missions risked breakdown long before reaching the target.

Veterans often described the sense of relief that came with spotting the brightly colored aircraft circling above the base. In the low morning light, with engines warming and visibility uncertain, that visual cue gave crews a clear point of reference. They knew exactly where to go and how to start the long climb eastward.

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standard-article(title: [The Nostalgia Bone (2021)], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([The global pandemic spawned a different type of epidemic, one of an entirely different nature: a nostalgia outbreak. Longing for 'simpler times' and 'better days', many of us turned to 90s dance playlists, TV sitcoms, and sports highlights. We looked for comfort and safety in the permanence of the past, or at least, what we think the past was. But, when it first appeared, nostalgia itself wasn't considered a feeling; it was a deadly disease. This episode traces the history of nostalgia from its origins as an illness to the dominating emotion of our time. And in doing so, we wrestle with its eternal paradox to both hold us back and keep us going.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 154, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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standard-article(title: [[Outliers] The Multidisciplinary Approach to Thinking | Peter D. Kaufman], author: [Vicky], source-name: [Farnam Street (fs.blog)], images: (), paragraphs: ([One of the people I've learned the most from is Peter D. Kaufman.], [Peter has been the chairman and CEO of GlenAir since 1977. And he's got a track record that puts him in the top 0.001% of business leaders during that time. He's also the editor of Poor Charlie's Almanack and was one of Charlie Munger's closest friends for decades.], [In a talk never meant to be made public, he revealed the secrets of multidisciplinary thinking. Someone unfortunately recorded the talk without his permission. It became hugely popular, and eventually Peter allowed the complete talk to be transcribed and posted on FS.], [It's time to listen and learn.], [Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | X | Transcript], [+ Dive deeper into Mental Models.], [The post [Outliers] The Multidisciplinary Approach to Thinking | Peter D. Kaufman appeared first on Farnam Street .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 144, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Iran Protests Explained], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Editor's note: The United States and Israel launched attacks on Iran early Saturday, Feb. 28. For current coverage click here . For background context, the story below was published on Jan. 22, 2026.], [Iran has been here before. For decades the country has gone through cycles of protest and repression at the hands of the Islamic Republic. What makes this cycle different?], [In this episode of Throughline from NPR, we speak to two Iranian experts about their view of the past, present, and future of Iran's protest movement.], [Guests: Ali Alfoneh , senior fellow at the Arab Gulf States Institute in Washington DC Holly Dargès , senior fellow at the Washington Institute and curator of the Iranist on Substack.], [To access bonus episodes and listen to Throughline sponsor-free, subscribe to Throughline+ via Apple Podcasts or at plus.npr.org/throughline .], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and

standard-article(title: [[Outliers] Ray Kroc: How McDonald's Took Over America], author: [Vicky], source-name: [Farnam Street (fs.blog)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Ray Kroc turned McDonald's from a single roadside restaurant into a system built to scale.], [At 52, after decades of selling paper cups and milkshake machines, he opened the first McDonald's in 1955 and helped grow it to nearly 8,000 restaurants worldwide.], [This Outliers episode breaks down how standards, execution, franchising, and real estate created a business machine built to last.], [Available Now: Apple Podcasts | Spotify | YouTube | X | Transcript], [+ Members have access to my highlights from Grinding it Out , the book used as the basis for this episode, as well as to the repository, which offers all of my highlights.], ["I was an overnight success all right. But thirty years is a long, long night."], ["As long as you're green, you're growing. As soon as you're ripe, you start to rot."], [Define yourself by what problems you solve, not what you sell.], [Do a few things. Do them perfectly.], [Trust isn't built in grand gestures. It's built when you could take the last slice and don't.], ["You must perfect every fundamental of your business if you expect it to perform well."], [What you refuse to do matters more than what you do.], [The best ideas don't come from headquarters. They come from people close to the problem.], [Leverage comes from being willing to walk away.], [When you can't convince someone with logic, remove their objections: "It costs you nothing to try."], [Land one big account and grow with them. Let the system sell itself.], [Invention is not enough. Replication at scale is its own kind of genius.], ["Nothing recedes like success."], [Work from the part to the whole. Don't move to big ideas until you've perfected the small details.], [Build when times are bad.], [The best salespeople know when to stop talking.], [Dreams are only wasted if they're not linked to action.], [Stress your own strengths. The competition will wear itself out trying to keep up.], [If you can't sell yourself, you'll never sell anything.], [If you hire someone to do a job, get out of the way and let them do it. If you doubt their ability, you shouldn't have hired them.], [Income can appear in many forms. A satisfied smile means they're coming back with a friend.], [The post [Outliers] Ray Kroc: How McDonald's Took Over America appeared first on Farnam Street .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 393, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [The Lavender Scare (Throwback)], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([One day in late April 1958, a young economist named Madeleine Tress was approached by two men in suits at her office at the U. S. Department of Commerce. They took her to a private room, turned on a tape recorder, and demanded she respond to allegations that she was an "admitted homosexual." Two weeks later, she resigned.], [Madeleine was one of thousands of victims of a purge of gay and lesbian people ordered at the highest levels of the U. S. government: a program spurred

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standard-article(title: [The First Department of Education], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Whose job is it to educate Americans? Congress created the first Department of Education just after the Civil War as a way to help reunify a broken country. A year later, it was basically shut down. But the story of that first department's birth – and death – set the stage for everything that's come since.], [To access bonus episodes and listen to Throughline sponsor-free, subscribe to Throughline+ via Apple Podcasts or at plus.npr.org/throughline .], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 115, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [From the Frontlines], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Journalism is under unprecedented threat worldwide. At least 220 journalists have been killed in Gaza alone since the October 7th, 2023 Hamas-led attack on Israel; the Committee to Protect Journalists says it's the deadliest conflict for journalists the group has ever documented. In conflicts around the world, it's war reporters who write the first draft of history. But getting to the front lines, finding the truth, and reporting it is easier said

by a panic that destroyed careers and lives and lasted more than forty years. Today, it's known as the "Lavender Scare.", [In a moment when LGBTQ+ rights are again in the public crosshairs, we tell the story of the Lavender Scare: its victims, its proponents, and a man who fought for decades to end it.], [To access bonus episodes and listen to Throughline sponsor-free, subscribe to Throughline+ via Apple Podcasts or at plus.npr.org/throughline.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 197, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Aftermath (2020)], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([In 1927, the most destructive river flood in U. S. history inundated seven states, displaced more than half a million people for months, and caused about \$1 billion dollars in property damages. And like many national emergencies it exposed a stark question that the country still struggles to answer - what is the political calculus used to decide who bears the ultimate responsibility in a crisis, especially when it comes to the most vulnerable? This week, the Great Mississippi Flood of 1927 and what came after.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 125, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [American Exile], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([For centuries, the United States has been a prime destination for migrants hoping for better economic opportunities, fleeing danger in their home countries or just seeking a new life. But has there ever been a moment when Americans were the ones who felt compelled to flee elsewhere? In this episode, two stories that challenge the idea of who and why Americans sought refuge in other countries.], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 106, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

than done. Today on the show: war reporters, and what's at stake if they can't do their jobs.

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standard-article(title: [The Lord Of Misrule (Throwback)], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([By the time his book went to press in London, on November 18, 1633, Thomas Morton had been exiled from the Puritan colonies in Massachusetts. His crimes: drinking, carousing, and — crucially — building social and economic ties with Native people. His book outlined a vision for what America could become. A very different vision than that of the Puritans.], [But the book wouldn't be published that day. It wouldn't be published for years. Because agents for the Puritan colonists stormed the press and destroyed every copy.], [Today on the show, the story of what's widely considered America's first banned book, the radical vision it conjured, and the man who outlined that vision: Thomas Morton, the Lord of Misrule.], [To access bonus episodes and listen to Throughline sponsor-free, subscribe to Throughline+ via Apple Podcasts or at plus.npr.org/throughline .], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about our collection and use of personal data for sponsorship and to manage your podcast sponsorship preferences.], [Learn more about sponsor message choices: podcastchoices.com/adchoices], [NPR Privacy Policy],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 178, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [The Monster of We (2021)], author: [Throughline (NPR)], source-name: [Throughline (NPR)], images: (), paragraphs: ([Are most modern problems caused by selfishness or a lack of it? Ayn Rand, a Russian American philosopher and writer, would say it's the latter — that selfishness is not a vice but a virtue — and that capitalism is the ideal system. Everyone from Donald Trump, to Alan Greenspan, to Brad Pitt have sung Ayn Rand's praises. The Library of Congress named her novel *Atlas Shrugged* the second most influential book in the U. S. after the Bible. Ayn Rand wasn't politically correct, she was belligerent and liked going against the grain. And although she lived by the doctrine of her own greatness, she was driven by the fear that she would never be good enough.], [In this episode, historian Jennifer Burns will guide us through Rand's evolution and how she eventually reshaped American politics, becoming what Burns calls "a gateway drug to life on the right."], [To manage podcast ad preferences, review the links below:], [See pcm.adswizz.com for information about

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The X On The Map

Throughline (NPR)

In 1965, Jimmie Lee Jackson was an unarmed black civil rights activist who was murdered in Marion, Ala., after a peaceful protest. His murder brought newfound energy to the civil rights movement, leading to the march to Montgomery that ended in “Bloody Sunday.” This week, we share an episode we loved from White Lies as they look for answers to a murder that happened more than half a century ago.

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